Session 25

2025-10-26

1 - The fight continues

~14:00, 21 Nightal 1489 DR

1. The mountain pass fight is still raging. Six cultists are down — three dead, three dropped by Mialee's blades under her fog, now thinned. Kaelthar is on the ground; Amidamaru's healing has kept the breath in him. Nuberroca holds **Sulesdeg** off behind the broken wagon, a bolt in his bleeding side.
2. Nuberroca blurs to mist and reappears behind the near cart for cover. Sulesdeg — wounded while trying to arrest him unarmed — now has his sword out and is swinging to kill; the lead cultist works the surviving caravan guards against the party, shouting that these adventurers are robbers who have murdered his companions. A second crossbow bolt catches Nuberroca at the lip of his cover.
3. Amidamaru reads Sulesdeg coming through to finish Kaelthar on the ground and steps across to catch the captain's wrist — a hand on the arm, *"please, bear with me,"* no blow. Sulesdeg pushes through regardless; he throws himself across Kaelthar, pins him down, and snaps a pair of irons on his wrists. Kaelthar tries to answer with a tail-strike from under the knee but the angle is wrong and it goes nowhere.
4. Mialee has climbed up on one of the carts. She throws down a convincing-looking parchment — an illusion of a mandate sealed with the **Order of the Gauntlet's mark** — and calls out that they are the ***Heroes of Mansken***, sent by **Ontharr Frume** on a sanctioned mission against the raiders of Greenest and Greenfields. Her unseen hand works the lid of the nearest crate to show the plunder, but the lid comes up on rations. The lead cultist takes the opening — *"they're liars, they're deceiving you with illusions"* — and the caravan guards hold, undecided.
5. **Eldkin** advances on Nuberroca with a pair of irons in her hand. Nuberroca swings as she approaches but misses. The dwarf then drops the shackles, draws her spear, and charges the barbarian.
6. Amidamaru takes the lead cultist to the ground in a grapple. Mialee follows and sets a dagger to his throat, telling him to confess with a look hard enough to make him flinch, afraid. Her unseen hand lifts the lid of another crate while she speaks — jewellery, chalices, religious icons in precious metal, some of them still bloodied.
7. On the other flank Nyx goes to **Lai** and tells him to trust her, she is going to help calm the fight. She crosses behind Eldkin, tells her to stop — they are going to solve all this — and grapples her, Nuberroca flanking from the other side. The barbarian then unspools the rope out of his pack and binds the dwarf while Nyx murmurs that it will not be long, soft words close by her ear.

2 - Chests and pendant

1. The fight ends with the lead cultist on the ground under Mialee's dagger and Eldkin bound in Nuberroca's rope beside him. Sulesdeg finally comes off Kaelthar, lifts him up to unlock the irons on his wrists, pushes past him without a word, and goes to Lai to swear quietly at him about what has just happened. On the way past, Amidamaru closes on him and lays a hand on his back — a soft light passes through Sulesdeg, the wound in his shoulder closes under it, and the captain walks on as furious as before.
2. Amidamaru goes through the dead cultists' pockets. There is nothing of note on them beyond their arms, except that one of them is wearing a fine golden dragon pendant. He pockets it.
3. **Beyd**'s instruction is that the party should prove the goods are what they say. Sulesdeg sets his sword into the lid of one of the crates and splits it open; what spills is what the party has been saying — chalices, religious icons in precious metal, bags of gems prised from temple statues, a few pieces smeared with old blood. The four lead merchants — **Edhelri**, **Noohar**, Lai, and Beyd — pull apart from the rest and talk it over.
4. Beyd's first proposal, overheard, is to bury the cultists on the road and share the plunder among the surviving merchants and guards. Amidamaru cuts in — the gold has to go back to the villages it was taken from, through the Order of the Gauntlet; Nyx steps up behind him with the same line — they have tracked these cultists all the way from Greenest and will not see the loot broken up at the roadside.
5. ***[EPIC]*** As Amidamaru's words carry — *the Order of the Gauntlet* — Nuberroca stands tall and lets his frame grow to giant size behind him; he hauls the furs off his shoulders and shows the great fist blazoned on the breastplate underneath.
6. Nuberroca rounds on the merchants — the Company of the Boar they had hired for protection bolted the night the trolls came, the party and the caravan guards paid for it, and now these same merchants want to carve up stolen gold between them. Mialee opens the door a crack to gifting the humble family a coin or two, but no more than that.
7. Lai sides with the party against the carve-up — pack the crates into two carts, abandon the third for parts, run the whole load to Waterdeep, and let the city's justice resolve the ownership.

3 – Papers of the dead

1. Searching the wagons for papers Amidamaru turns up a note that names the destination as ***Carnath***, a roadhouse along the Trade Way past Waterdeep. Mialee remembers *Castle Naerytar* as destination, though no one in the party can place where it is. Amidamaru also prises three or four rubies and small stones from the loot for his own scroll work.
2. The practical work takes the rest of the daylight. Amidamaru patches the broken family wagon out of parts cannibalised from the one being abandoned. Nuberroca brings the humble family forward — **Gus** and **Darla**, with **Anton** travelling with them — and moves their wagon to third position so he can keep eyes on both the family and the cultists at once.
3. **Paco** — the cultist guard Amidamaru had grown fond of, scorched during the fight — is laid out apart from the others at the tortle's insistence. Amidamaru closes his eyes and covers him with a blanket. Nuberroca — still large from the breastplate moment — heaps the other two cultist dead in a pile and sets the surviving suspect propped against one of them, *"we'll talk later, criminal"*.

4 – A buried cultist

~16:00, 21 Nigħtal 1489 DR

1. The party splits into two groups to work on the four live captives. Nuberroca, Mialee, and Eguzkilore take the apparent leader — the one Mialee had on the ground — out past the carts; Amidamaru, Kaelthar, and Nyx take the other three to the opposite side.
2. Eguzkilore digs a pit and the three of them put the lead cultist in it up to the neck, blindfolded with a strip torn off his own shirt. Nuberroca lies down face to face with him and asks whether he would rather speak now and die with honour or die like the rat he is. The cultist's answer comes level: *"Tiamat's kingdom will come soon, and my sacrifices will not be in vain. I have no fear of death"*.
3. Nuberroca lets the fury take him to scare the prisoner — but the cultist holds against fear and intimidation both; he answers only with the dogma of his cult — the world will be a better place under the dragons. Nuberroca plants the lance a few inches from the cultist's face: *"you are this close to your goddess, right now"*. The cultist does not break.
4. ***[EPIC]*** Mialee sets a small wooden chest down on the ground beside the cultist's head and conjures an illusion out of it — four scorpions, clambering over the rim and walking toward his bound-eyed face. Nyx, as the illusion carries them in, lays a sound of her own under it — the dry rasp of claws on gravel, so close the cultist feels it on his cheek. The cultist breaks. The caravan's destination was always to cross Waterdeep and go on a little further to Carnath Roadhouse; the goods were for the Lady Dragon, whose colour he gives as black.

5 – The pendant trick

1. On the other side of the camp Amidamaru hangs the cultists' dragon pendant around his own neck, slaps the prisoners awake, and casts a charm across all three of them at once; two shake it off, the third — the sergeant — settles into looking at Amidamaru like a friend. Amidamaru leans into the role, pendant forward, and asks the sergeant who he is supposed to meet at Carnath Roadhouse.
2. The sergeant has nothing to give him. He is not a cultist at all — a mercenary hired out of Baldur's Gate to run with the caravan as far as Waterdeep, no questions asked about who paid him or what the cargo was. He has watched his companions die, he does not want to go the same way, and he asks only to be released and allowed to walk to the next town on his own feet. The sense of him sits sincere, so the party lets him go.
3. Amidamaru turns to the second — a true believer. Pendant forward, the tortle presses him on the cult's work and who waits at Carnath; the cultist answers with doctrine — Tiamat's rule will be better than any king's, the gold is needed for her return, and the party have killed without trial and are no cleaner than the cult. Nyx steps up at Amidamaru's shoulder — if the mediators lie, if a dragon-ruler would enslave rather than care — but between the two of them they get only more doctrine. *"I'd rather die than betray my own,"* the cultist says at the end, and Amidamaru leaves him tied against the cart.
4. Nyx takes the last of the three aside and asks him in a low voice what he can offer for his life. His answers come back the same as his companion's — the goods are for the Lady Dragon, colour black. Kaelthar, close enough to listen in, asks the dragon's name and the cultist reluctantly answers: **Rezmir**; he then asks whether they are guarding sacred eggs for the lady, and the cultist tells him no — he would consider that an enormous honour. Nyx slaps the cultist once across the face and leaves it there.
5. At dusk, with the interrogations wrapped and the prisoners tied behind the carts, the three dead cultists burn under Kaelthar's dragon-breath — the two in the pile and Paco where he had been laid apart — so nothing comes back out of the mountain at night. Amidamaru shapes a small glowing stone to mark Paco's resting place.

6 - Throats cut

~19:00, 21 Nightal 1489 DR

1. The caravan agrees, with some reluctance, to stay with the party; they can tell from the way the merchants look at them now that something has shifted. The convoy is too far behind to reach the next town before dark and makes a cold camp off the road halfway in. The watch is organised badly — Amidamaru first, Nyx second, Eguzkilore for the long end, Nuberroca, Kaelthar, and Mialee not actually on the rotation at all because the decanting of hours did not get worked through properly.
2. The party wakes to find the cultists tied behind the carts dead in their bindings — throats cut, cleanly done, only one of the three left alive. When the survivor is woken he panics at the sight of his dead companions; Mialee backhands him demanding what he saw and the man swears, shaking, that he knows nothing. Nuberroca puts his experience with corpses on the bodies and determines the death at about five hours earlier — Nyx's watch, by the counting-back.
3. Nyx walks the ground around the cart as the camp wakes. She can read the trace of someone who came up on the carts well before her patrol passed, and the patrol tracks that walked across those tracks afterwards — her own, going by — but the ground is bare stone and the trail does not carry beyond that. Kaelthar casts his sense out for any undead or celestial lingering nearby and finds nothing. Nobody saw anything on any of the watches.
4. Mialee goes around the camp while people are breaking fast, looking for blood on anyone's clothes. She finds a smear on the sole of Eguzkilore's shoe — a single mark, nowhere else on him. He claims he must have stepped in it while looking at the body. The sense of him sits uncertain, but she lets it rest.

7 - Daggerford

~13:00, 22 Nightal 1489 DR

1. The caravan makes Daggerford four hours after breakfast, where the merchants settle to lose the day in town and set out again the next morning. Sulesdeg and a knot of guards stay with the parked carts. Nuberroca has the surviving cultist tied against his chest facing outwards all the way in — like a baby in a sling, so the prisoner has to look at everything Nuberroca looks at — mouth gagged at Mialee's insistence. Mialee stays close while Nuberroca carries him into the tavern and drinks beer in his face, drool falling on him: *"you thought death was the worst thing that could happen to you"*. Every eye in the place is on them.
2. The errands move quickly. Eguzkilore buys arrows at a stall but otherwise sticks close to the carts; Amidamaru fills Mialee's order for incense and takes a few extra for his own work; Nuberroca asks after rope and Nyx hands him hers off her belt — she has plenty. Amidamaru also asks after a smith in town for a commission he intends to settle.
3. Nyx passes Eguzkilore the magical longbow she has carried since the golden stag crossed their path and takes his ordinary longbow in exchange; neither of them makes a fuss about it, the trade is just quietly done over a drink.

8 - The elf at the gate

~09:00, 23 Nightal 1489 DR

1. The next morning the caravan goes out light. The noble with his mage and his guard are stopping in Daggerford for their own business; the mercenary hired by the cult has walked off before the caravan rolled out; and the two sisters — **Arietta** and **Zelina** — are gone. Nobody saw them leave and nobody remembers when they last saw them. Nuberroca jokes that it might have been the sisters who did the cultist in the night.
2. There are also two new faces in the caravan where the departures leave gaps. A small gnome woman with knives sewn into the folds of her clothes who moves fluidly and watches the party — Nuberroca particularly, with his strapped prisoner — with open attention. And a man dressed in black, hooded, who speaks to no one and travels alone.
3. As the carts are rolling out an elf comes down the road toward them at a hard gallop. He is tattooed on the face and carries more knives than the party can count — not drawn, kept — and asks the Daggerford traffic quickly as he rides, person by person, about a dwarf. He stops at Lai and Eldkin: *"I'm looking for a dwarf like you. He has a mark here — a tree tattooed on the nape of his neck"*. He turns to the great blue goliath with the human bound to his chest and hesitates.
4. Nuberroca lifts the strapped prisoner by way of answer. The elf takes one look, says flatly that the thing bound to the goliath's chest is a human and the goliath himself the strangest thing on the road, then names what he is after — *"I'm looking for a dwarf. He thinks he's a god. He calls himself Sinsong"*. Nuberroca's grin changes.
5. The barbarian rolls up a sleeve — Sinsong healed the scar across his arm. The elf fires back that Sinsong probably put it there in the first place, because he is a bastard. Nuberroca invites him to ride on with the caravan: last they saw of the dwarf he was on the back of a chicken, so he will likely turn up. The elf wheels his horse away — if the party finds him, tell him **Elodin** is looking for him — and rides out at the gallop he came in on, north, the same road the caravan is about to take; the convoy rolls out behind him.